backyards, or streets. By 2024, more than 600,000 people were participating, recording 9.7 million birds. The vast amount of data gathered can now be compared for every year back to 1979. Without public help, this would simply not be possible.

In 1989, the term “citizen science” first appeared in print, in the journal *American Birds*. It was used to describe a volunteer project sponsored by the Audubon Society that sampled rain for acidity. The aim of the project was to raise awareness of the acidification of rivers and lakes that was killing fish and invertebrates, and, indirectly, the birds that preyed on them. It was also designed to put pressure on the US government, which soon after introduced the 1990 Clean Air Act.

Citizen science has also proved its worth for marine conservation. In the Bahamas, a report in 2012 on declining numbers of the queen conch, a large sea snail, led to the formation of “Conchservation,” a campaign that encourages locals to tag conches. Another project, set up in the US in 2010, at the University of Georgia, uses an app, the Marine Debris Tracker, to record sightings of debris in the ocean. Understanding patterns of trash buildup in the world’s seas helps scientists to track how it is transported by currents and where to concentrate removal efforts for maximum effect.

The advent of new technology has led to a proliferation of citizen science projects. Online recording systems allow people to log sightings of anything from stag beetles to wildflowers or migrating birds. In the UK, for example, the Greenspace Information for Greater London (GiGL) website, created by the National Biodiversity Network, allows people to submit records online or by phone, adding to a database used by scientists working to conserve species and habitats.